



A Doll's House Literary Devices & Authorial Choices

Henrik Ibsen
IB English Literature



Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

Identify major literary devices used throughout *A Doll's House*.

Explain how Ibsen deliberately employs these devices for effect.

Analyse the impact of these devices on the audience's experience.

Connect literary devices to themes and character development.

Quick Starter

"What might a house represent besides a place to live?"

Before we begin, consider the world of A Doll's House. Think about the spaces we inhabit — the doors we open, the rooms we are confined to, the keys we do or do not hold.

Select all the meanings a house might represent. Be ready to explain your thinking — there is no single correct answer.



Tap or click to respond:

 Security

— A place of safety and belonging

 Imprisonment

— A space of control and confinement

 Identity

— A reflection of who we are or who we perform

 Social Expectations

— A stage for meeting society's demands

Discuss: Can a house represent all of these at once? How does Ibsen use the Helmers' home to explore these ideas?

Literary Devices

Literary Device

Language tools used by an author to convey deeper meaning, emotion, and ideas — e.g., symbolism, irony, metaphor.

Dramatic Technique

Methods specific to theatrical performance that shape how an audience experiences a play — e.g., stage directions, props, silence, entrances and exits.

Symbolism

When an object, character, or event represents a concept beyond its literal meaning — e.g., the doll's house as a symbol of confinement.

Authorial Choice

Deliberate creative decisions made by Ibsen to guide audience interpretation, shape character, and communicate social criticism.



Symbolism in *A Doll's House*

Doll's House

Literal: family home → Symbol: cage, illusion, control

Christmas Tree

Literal: festive decoration → Symbol: Nora's façade, decay

Macaroons

Literal: forbidden sweets → Symbol: Nora's secret defiance

Door & Key

Literal: household objects → Symbol: power, access, escape

Tarantella

Literal: folk dance → Symbol: desperation, performance

Letterbox

Literal: mail slot → Symbol: threat, truth, turning point



Nora as a Doll

Ibsen uses the "doll" metaphor to expose Nora's lack of autonomy within her marriage and society.

- Infantilisation: Torvald uses pet names — "little lark," "little squirrel" — reducing Nora to a child.
- Control: Every action, appearance, and expense is monitored and managed by Torvald.
- Gender Roles: Nora performs the role of ideal wife, suppressing her true self to meet social expectations.
- Performance: Like a doll, Nora exists to please — she dances, decorates, and obeys on command.
- Lack of Autonomy: She has no legal, financial, or emotional independence.

"I have been performing tricks for you, Torvald. That's how I've survived."

— Nora, Act III



Metaphor in the Play

Nora's Marriage: a performance of obedience — "He calls me his doll-wife, and he plays with me just as I used to play with my dolls."

The Household: a gilded cage — comfort masking control; domesticity as imprisonment

Social Expectations: a costume worn daily — identity shaped by others' gaze, not one's own

Nora's Transformation: a metamorphosis — from ornament to autonomous self — "I must stand quite alone, if I am to understand myself and everything about me."



Irony



Dramatic Irony

The audience knows Nora's secret loan before Torvald — creating unbearable tension as he praises her virtue.

Situational Irony

Torvald, who preaches moral integrity, abandons Nora the moment his own reputation is threatened — the opposite of what his words promise.

Nora's Secret

Her act of forgery was an act of love — yet it is treated as criminal betrayal, exposing the gap between intention and social judgment.

Torvald's Hypocrisy

"I would gladly work night and day for you" — yet when tested, he chooses reputation over love, revealing the hollowness of his devotion.

Audience's Greater Knowledge

We watch Torvald celebrate Nora's "innocence" knowing the full truth — Ibsen weaponises our knowledge to expose patriarchal blindness.

💬 Discussion: "Who understands Nora least — Torvald, society, or Nora herself?"

Consider: Which character's misreading of Nora is most damaging to her identity and freedom?

Foreshadowing: Predict What Happens Next



Nora's Secret: Her hidden loan hints at a reckoning — deception cannot remain concealed forever.

Macaroons: Nora's small rebellions signal a deeper defiance waiting to emerge.

The Letter: Krogstad's letter in the box looms as an inevitable moment of exposure and crisis.

The Tarantella: Nora's frantic, desperate dance foreshadows emotional collapse and loss of control.

Reputation & Morality: Torvald's rigid moral code signals the devastating conflict to come.

🔍 Activity: "Based on these clues, what do you predict will happen next?"

Dramatic Irony Timeline

WHAT NORA KNOWS

- She forged her father's signature to secure a loan
- Krogstad holds the bond — and the secret
- She has been secretly repaying the debt for years
- The tarantella is a desperate distraction
- She is planning to end her own life

WHAT TORVALD KNOWS

- Nora is his devoted, dependent "little lark"
- He believes he is Nora's protector and moral guide
- He sees only her performance — never her reality
- He is unaware of the loan, the forgery, or the threat
- He discovers the truth only when the letter is opened



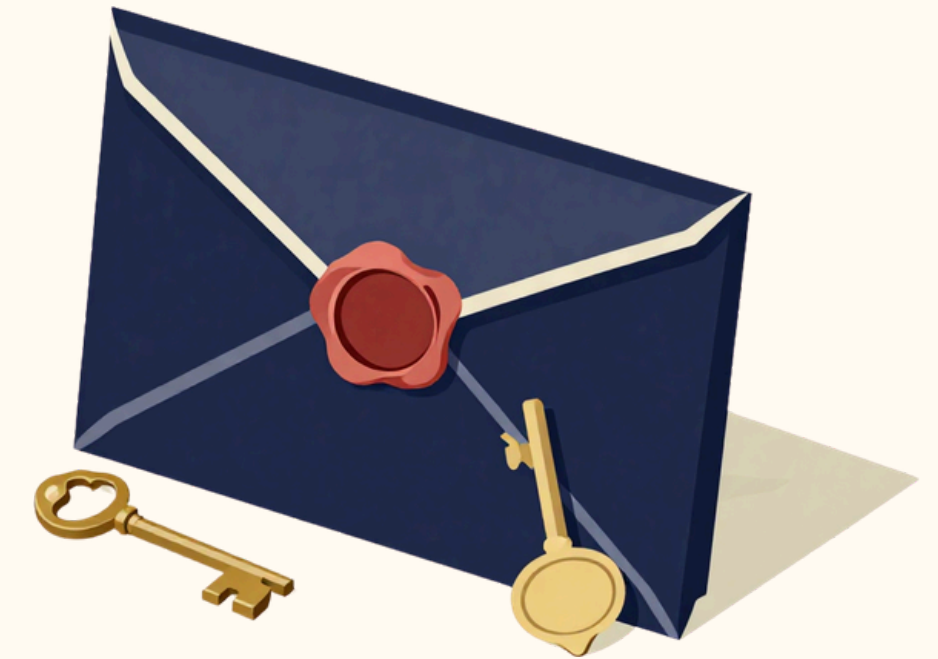
WHAT THE AUDIENCE KNOWS

- Everything — Ibsen reveals Nora's secret in Act I
- We watch Torvald's ignorance with growing unease
- We understand Nora's fear, desperation, and courage
- We see the gap between appearance and reality
- We anticipate the inevitable confrontation

EFFECT OF DRAMATIC IRONY

- Creates sustained tension and emotional engagement
- Positions the audience as privileged, critical observers
- Deepens sympathy for Nora and critique of Torvald
- Ibsen's tool for exposing patriarchal blindness
- The final door slam lands with devastating impact

Motifs: Recurring Ideas and Objects



Money: Represents power, dependence, and moral compromise — Nora's loan exposes the transactional nature of her marriage.

Doors: Repeated entrances and exits signal control, escape, and the boundary between public and private life.

Letters: Written words carry secrets, threats, and truth — each letter shifts the balance of power between characters.

Secrets: Hidden knowledge drives tension; the gap between what is known and concealed defines every relationship.

Appearance vs Reality: Characters perform roles for social approval, masking their true selves beneath a respectable facade.

Performance: From Nora's tarantella to her daily behaviour, identity itself becomes an act staged for others' expectations.



Imagery

Ibsen uses vivid imagery to build atmosphere and reinforce theme throughout the play:

- Christmas — warmth and festivity masking hidden tension and deception beneath the surface
- The Home — domestic comfort as a gilded cage; beauty concealing confinement
- Dance (Tarantella) — wild, desperate movement evoking fear, performance, and loss of control
- Darkness & Light — moral clarity vs. concealment; truth emerging from shadow
- Confinement — closed rooms, locked doors, and small spaces reflecting Nora's psychological imprisonment

Through layered imagery, Ibsen transforms the domestic setting into a space of emotional and social suffocation.

Contrast & Juxtaposition

Nora vs Torvald

Nora seeks selfhood; Torvald demands obedience. She is emotional and intuitive; he is rational and controlling. She sacrifices secretly; he claims moral authority publicly.

Nora vs Mrs Linde

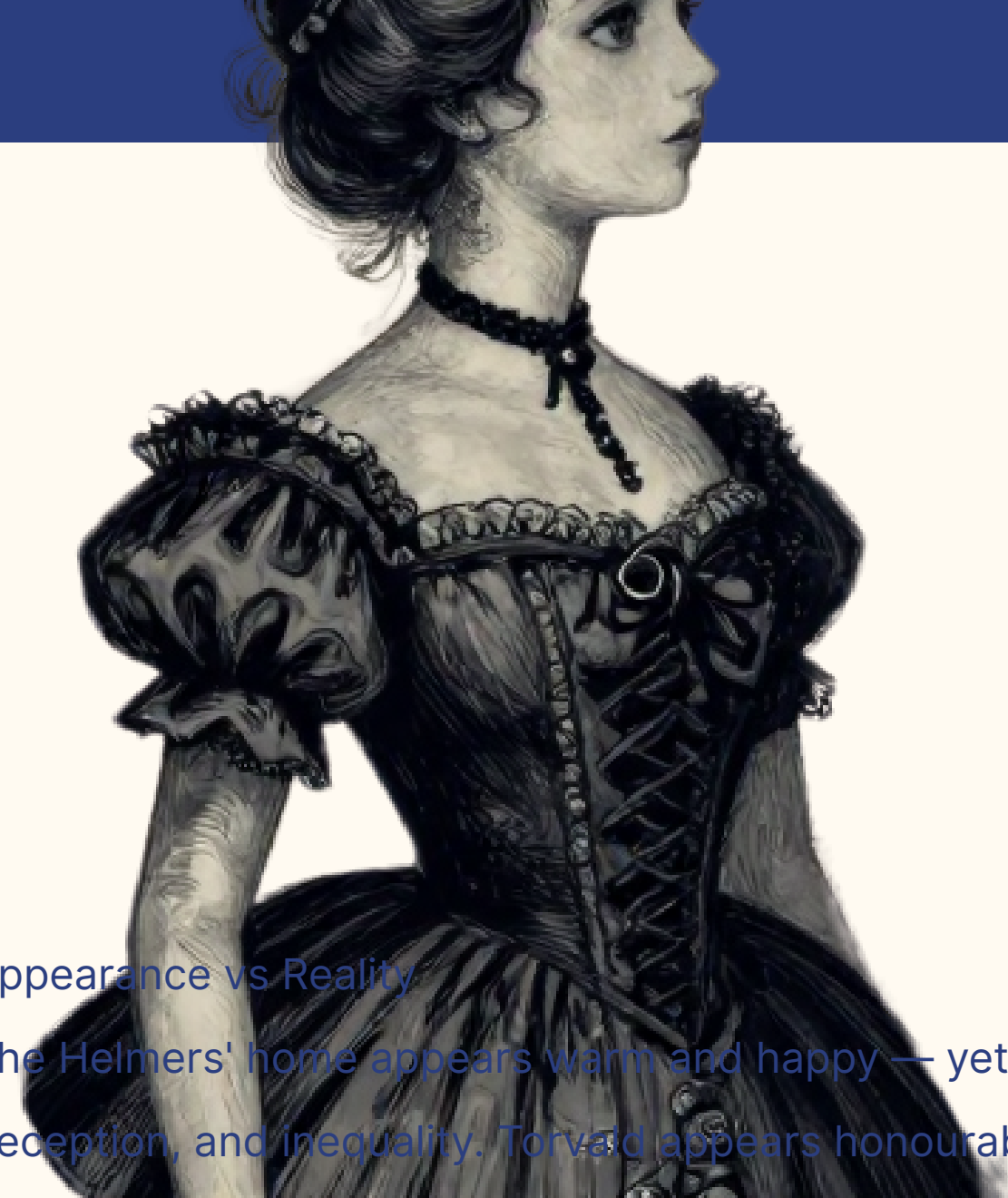
Nora is sheltered and dependent; Mrs Linde is independent and self-reliant. Nora performs happiness; Mrs Linde endures hardship openly. Their contrast highlights the limits placed on women.

Appearance vs Reality

The Helmers' home appears warm and happy — yet conceals debt, deception, and inequality. Torvald appears honourable; Nora appears childlike. Neither is what they seem.

Freedom vs Confinement

The domestic space confines Nora physically and socially. The door symbolises both barrier and escape. Torvald's "protection" is control. The final slam marks the collision of these opposites.



Characterisation Techniques



Dialogue: Reveals character through word choice, tone, and what is left unsaid — e.g., Torvald's pet names infantilise Nora.

Actions: Characters are defined by behaviour under pressure — Nora's secret loan reveals courage and desperation.

Relationships: Dynamics with others expose power, dependency, and identity — Nora vs. Mrs. Linde contrasts constraint with independence.

Stage Directions: Ibsen uses movement, silence, and physical space to communicate inner states — the final exit is entirely wordless.

Other Characters' Opinions: Outside perspectives shape audience perception — Krogstad and Dr. Rank each illuminate different facets of Nora's world.

Dramatic Techniques in the Play

Stage Directions

Props

Dialogue

Entrances & Exits

Setting

Costume

Silence

The Door Slam



The Tarantella

Ibsen uses the tarantella dance as a powerful multi-layered dramatic device:

- Performance — Nora performs femininity and submission for Torvald's gaze
- Distraction — She buys time, controlling the moment through movement
- Emotional Expression — The wild dance externalises her inner desperation
- Symbol of Desperation — Frantic energy mirrors her psychological collapse

"Dance it as if your life depended on it." — And it does.

💬 Is Nora dancing for herself, Torvald, or society?



The Letter

Krogstad's letter in the letterbox is the play's pivotal dramatic device — a physical object that transforms into a symbol of revelation and inevitable reckoning.

- Revelation — exposes Nora's secret forgery to Torvald
- Suspense — the sealed letter builds unbearable dramatic tension
- Threat — represents Krogstad's power and Nora's vulnerability
- Truth — forces reality to shatter the "doll's house" illusion
- Loss of Control — Nora can no longer manage appearances or protect her world

Ibsen uses the letter to shift the entire direction of the play. The audience, already aware of its contents through dramatic irony, watches Torvald's world collapse — revealing his true character and Nora's awakening.



The Door Slam

Ibsen's final stage direction — a door slamming shut — is one of the most iconic moments in modern drama. It symbolises:

- Separation — Nora severs her domestic role
- Freedom — she chooses self over society
- Rejection — of Torvald, marriage, and expectation
- Transformation — from doll to autonomous woman
- Social Rebellion — a direct challenge to Victorian norms

"Is the final door slam an ending — or a beginning?"



Literary Devices + Themes Matrix

Symbolism

Irony

Motif

Foreshadowing

Contrast

Dramatic Techniques

Gender & Identity

Appearance vs Reality

Control & Freedom

Secrets & Consequences

Gender Expectations

Social Criticism



IB Analysis Formula

DEVICE → EVIDENCE → EFFECT → PURPOSE → THEME →
AUTHORIAL MESSAGE

Worked Example: Symbolism of the Door

- Device: Symbolism
- Evidence: Nora's final exit and the door slam in Act III
- Effect: Shocks the audience; signals irreversible change
- Purpose: To dramatise Nora's rejection of her domestic role
- Theme: Freedom vs. Confinement; Individual Identity
- Authorial Message: Ibsen challenges the Victorian ideal of the selfless wife, asserting the individual's right to self-determination



Spot the Device Interactive Quiz



1. "I have been performing tricks for you, Torvald." → Symbolism | Metaphor | Irony | Motif
2. "The Christmas tree shall not be seen until this evening." → Foreshadowing | Symbolism | Contrast | Dramatic Technique
3. "You have never loved me — you only thought it amusing to be in love with me." → Irony | Metaphor | Motif | Characterisation
4. [Nora dances the tarantella wildly, desperately.] → Dramatic Technique | Foreshadowing | Symbolism | Contrast
5. [She slams the door behind her.] → Motif | Dramatic Technique | Symbolism | Irony

Think Like an IB Student



1. What device is used? — Identify the literary or dramatic technique with precision.
2. What does it reveal? — Consider what the device exposes about character, theme, or society.
3. How does it affect the audience? — Analyse emotional, intellectual, or dramatic impact.
4. Why might Ibsen have chosen it? — Reflect on authorial intent and deliberate creative decisions.
5. Which theme is connected? — Link the device to a central theme: identity, freedom, appearance vs reality.

Higher-Level Discussion Questions



How do domestic objects — the house, door, letterbox — become symbols of oppression rather than comfort?

How does dramatic irony shape the audience's view of Nora throughout the play?

To what extent is Nora consciously performing a role, and when does she stop performing?

How do literary and dramatic techniques expose the patriarchal power structures within the Helmer household?

Does Ibsen present Nora's freedom at the end as liberating, frightening, or both — and why?

Mini IB Exam Practice



Read the following passage carefully:

"Torvald: From this moment happiness is not the question; all that concerns us is to save the remains, the fragments, the appearance—"

"Nora: I have been performing tricks for you, Torvald. That's how I've survived. You wanted it so."

Analytical Question: "How does Ibsen use literary and dramatic devices in this passage to reveal the conflict between individual identity and social expectations?"

🕒 Allow 5 minutes for annotation and written reflection.

Annotation Checklist:

- Identify at least TWO literary devices
- Provide a direct quotation as evidence
- Explain the effect on the audience
- Link to Ibsen's authorial purpose
- Connect to a central theme

Consider: How does the language of "performance" and "appearance" expose the tension between Nora's true self and the role society demands she play? What does Torvald's focus on "appearance" reveal about patriarchal values in the play?

Exit Ticket & Reflection

"The most important literary device in A Doll's House is _____ because _____."

3-2-1 Reflection:

3 literary devices I can identify

2 quotations I can analyse

1 idea about Ibsen's authorial message

